Asian Journal of Women's Studies

ISSN: 1225-9276 (Print) 2377-004X (Online) Journal homepage: www.tandfonline.com/journals/rajw20

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To cite this article: Mary E. John (2020) Feminism, sexual violence and the times of #MeToo in India, Asian Journal of Women's Studies, 26:2, 137-158, DOI: 10.1080/12259276.2020.1748259

To link to this article: https://doi.org/10.1080/12259276.2020.1748259

Published online: 25 Jun 2020.

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ASIAN JOURNAL OF WOMEN'S STUDIES
2020, VOL. 26, NO. 2, 137–158
https://doi.org/10.1080/12259276.2020.1748259

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Feminism, sexual violence and the times of #MeToo in India

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ABSTRACT
This article begins with the aftermath of the Delhi gangrape in 2012, which shook India and the wider world. It examines what new insights emerged as sexual violence and harassment became a touchstone for naming what ails women in India, in public life and for feminist politics. The essay goes on to point out how the special focus on violence has obscured the contexts structuring and constraining young women students' aspirations, namely the peculiar twin developments of near parity in access to higher education coupled with one of the lowest female work participation rates in the world. The arrival of #MeToo in India from 1917, first in academia and then in several workplaces, brings in a further twist. Through the controversial staging of anonymous lists and collective testimonies through social media, the experience of #MeToo in India has revealed the ongoing force of a politics of naming acts of sexual harassment in a hostile climate where "job loss growth" is only going to increase most women's exclusion from employment and their greater dependency on men. I liken this contradiction to a new form of "hermeneutic injustice," which calls for vigilance and understanding as protests change their face yet again.

KEYWORDS Sexual violence; sexual harassment; Delhi gang rape; #MeToo; feminism in India; hermeneutic injustice

Introduction

In a pioneering essay from the 1990s, "Problems for a Contemporary Theory of Gender," Susie Tharu and Tejaswini Niranjana (1996) began provocatively with the statement "Suddenly, 'women' are everywhere" (p. 232).

The questions that essay chose to raise were about about some of the ways in which the subject of "the new woman"—sometimes even portrayed as a feminist one—was being deployed in the most significant events of the 1990s. This new subject could be found in the agitations against the implementation of reservations (quotas) for the Other Backward Castes (OBCs) in government services; the promotion of new long-acting contraceptives in family planning programs for women's empowerment by

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international agencies; the emergence of a militant female figure in the women's wing of the Hindu Right's Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) during the late 1980s; and in accounts of the village women leading the anti-arrack struggles in coastal Andhra Pradesh (in central India) in the early 1990s (Tharu & Niranjana, 1996).

A whole generation has since elapsed and we are now well into the twenty-first century. In these intervening decades, feminism, taken as short hand for the movement for women's rights in India, has truly come of age. The clearest sign of this is the widespread use of the term feminism itself, which, not so long ago, was treated rather gingerly or else avoided altogether, with "women" or "gender" being more frequently used.

Today, in spite of being up against a state formation that is the most hostile to gender equality and social justice in the history of modern India, or perhaps precisely because of it, there is a renewed urgency to speak up from identifiably feminist perspectives. Thus, feminist voices have been speaking out, whether it be against growing militarization, the ravages of neo-liberal development, the hierarchies of caste, the disenfranchisement of minorities, the exclusions of disability, or queer subjectivities.

In the midst of this kind of a renewal of a feminist politics, it might seem rather odd to raise questions about it. I take this perverse course in the hope of clarifying what our collective insights and blindnesses have been in the recent past. The main target of my questioning—which has had to double back on itself to make changes and corrections—is the visible centrality of sexual violence in contemporary feminist politics.

Just as Tharu and Niranjana (1996) once proclaimed, in a critical rather than celebratory tone, that women are suddenly everywhere, more than two decades later, I am tempted to say that suddenly sexual violence is everywhere. It is being recognized and called out in buses and on the street, in corporate boardrooms and university departments, in hostels and homes, in the "badlands" of a state like Haryana as much as in well-to-do metropolitan India. The list of places where it is gaining visibility today seems truly unending: from the violation of small children, mature adults, trans-people, and sexual minorities.

To put it more sharply, today, it seems as if violence has become a kind of touchstone for the recognition of an issue as a "women's issue." The presence of coercive force—in a whole range of acts from rape to sexual harassment—appears to crystallise feminist issues, renders them recognizable as such, and even enables them to acquire resonance within a larger, otherwise unsympathetic public. Just as an actual touchstone certified the purity of gold once upon a time, violence seems to authenticate an issue as genuinely addressing the wrongs of women in present day India.

My argument here is *not* that violence should not be allowed to function as a touchstone, nor do I wish to suggest that it is a bad or deficient one. Rather,

this essay is about my changing and still evolving relationship with violence-as-touchstone, from the aftermath of the gang rape of Jyoti Singh in Delhi on 16 December 2012 to the presently evolving #MeToo movement. It is both about what the focus on violence may have obscured, and what we might yet gain in thinking afresh about violence today. Therefore, this essay has its own twists and turns. I begin by suggesting that a new moment within the long history of engagement with violence by the women's movement in India can be traced to the December 2012 gang rape, such that sexual violence came to occupy a pre-eminent place in both activism and research. Acknowledging the many insights of this moment, I nonetheless go on to question the special identification of freedom and independence in the lives of young women with combatting violence and harassment. What such a focus has kept out of sight is the peculiar combination in India of near gender parity in enrollment in higher educational institutions, coupled with the fact that India has one of the world's lowest female employment rates, which are shockingly in decline. After all, what kind of autonomy can a new generation of more educated women hope to realize, including from violence, when the majority will be entirely economically and socially dependent on men? However, the arrival of #MeToo on Indian shores in academia in 2017 followed by testimonies from various workplaces a year later, has brought about yet another engagement with the subject of violence, just when I thought that it had been sufficiently publicized and politicized. This raises further questions for a feminist politics which I attempt to address in the conclusion.

What is new about sexual violence in India today?

The campaign against gendered violence was one of the crucial founding moments in the history of the contemporary women's movement in India, and it was followed by decades of campaigns and legal reforms.[1] Given its status as an inaugural issue in the early years of the women's movement in the late 1970s and 1980s, therefore, the first question to ask is what is new about the current preoccupation with sexual violence both within the women's movement and in public discourses more broadly? Why am I claiming a special significance for the struggles against sexual violence today when they are, after all, only a culmination of all that has come before?

It is broadly agreed that for reasons that we may not yet fully grasp, the gang rape of 16 December 2012 produced mass protests (and not just in the city of Delhi, but in several places both large and small) that were unprecedented in scope and caught the attention of the state, the media, and a global public as never before. The horrific and fatal nature of the gang rape undoubtedly played a large part in the national and international outcry that followed.[2] Responses included the setting up of the Justice Verma

Committee and the rapid enactments of the Criminal Amendment Act (2013) and the Sexual Harassment at Workplace Act (2013). Issues of sexual violence were brought into the very mainstream of public life in a way that decades of agitation had not been able to achieve. It also turned India and its so-called "rape capital" Delhi into a kind of state of exception on the world stage, provoking varied first-world responses towards the plight of Indian women. These included the setting up of a special Gender Task Force at Harvard to provide us with legal aid, and Leslee Udwin's controversial film *India's Daughter* that evoked comparisons to Katherine Mayo and the colonial civilizing mission.[3]

The Delhi case came dangerously close to cementing the hold of two popular myths: first, that the greatest danger to women lay in the stranger lurking in the streets after nightfall; and second, that the only way to curb such crimes was through the death penalty. Therefore, what made its aftermath so remarkable was that fresh directions and insights were gained for feminists in India by going *against* such common sense perceptions promoted by the Delhi rape case.

To begin with, there was a qualitative difference in the forms of the protest and of its feminist leadership. This difference was largely inspired, I suspect, by the repositioning of questions of sexuality since the 1990s. It was remarkable that the December 2012 protests not only demanded legal justice and an end to victimization, which was the more familiar path that earlier campaigns against rape had taken; they also asserted women's right to desire, to freedom and autonomy, and spoke out in the language of sexual rights. For every banner calling for death to the rapists (to which organizations belonging to the women's movement were strongly opposed), there were placards proclaiming "Don't ask me where I was last night," or "My dress is not a yes." The latter were held up by young women and girls, some of them in school uniform. The frequent cry of "Azadi" (the Urdu word for freedom, which bears a special political tenor) in the many gatherings that followed was a slogan that found new popularity, and had not been associated with mobilisations against rape.

Another difference was in some of the research undertaken at this time; in contrast to prior decades, when reflections on campaigns against violence and legal reform (rather than research on forms and experiences of violence) were critical. Activists and scholars examined sources of data like the National Crimes Record Bureau (NCRB) more closely. I have to confess that before this time, I did not know that, according to the national records on rape for the year 2011–12, in 98% of all the First Information Reports (FIRs) for rape lodged in India's police stations, the perpetrator was known to the victim.[4] If this was the official record, what of the situation on the ground, about which one could only speculate, given all the barriers against reporting rapes by someone known or in a position of power? The studies and

reports of this period upset assumptions about rape and violence. Two examples stand out. The investigations of Rukmini Srinivasan (2014) for *The Hindu* newspaper in Delhi revealed that for many years, the largest category of rape cases registered in Delhi come under the category of kidnaping and abduction. In fact, these are almost invariably cases against the young men or boys in eloping young couples registered by the parents of the girls; hence not really cases of rape at all and another major category is that of "promise to marry" (Srinivasan, 2014). A study conducted by the organization Rahat in Mumbai highlighted the prevalence of cases of incest by fathers/ step-fathers in families in this city: it was not known that such cases were almost as high as those of stranger rape.[5]

Thus, the Delhi gang rape stimulated research and insights precisely because it was a perfect case of stranger rape that fitted in only too well with the stereotype that needed to be dislodged. But one of its less noticed effects was that it crowded out media attention to the shocking avalanche of rapes of Dalit girls and women in the neighboring state of Haryana that were happening around the same time.

On the surface, these were cases of young school or college going girls aspiring for a better future for themselves, thereby inviting comparison with Jyoti Singh, the Delhi victim of December 2012. But the vital difference was that the respective social status of the victims and the perpetrators was reversed in the Haryana cases. Though from a modest middle-class background, Jyoti Singh was upper caste, training to begin a professional career as a physiotherapist; her attackers were members of the urban precariat, social dregs. By contrast, in neighboring semi-urban Haryana, girls and women from the lowest and most vulnerable castes were being raped by young men from their own neighborhoods who were (mostly) from the locally dominant Jat caste, capable of wielding influence where it mattered. Moreover, the aspiration for upward mobility implicit in the Dalit girls' quest for education ran against the grain of caste society. Thus, despite their surface similarity and their contiguity in time and space, the Delhi and Haryana rapes were worlds apart, which conspired to make the whole question of justice so elusive in Haryana compared to the swiftness with which it seemed to be achieved in Delhi (Women against Sexual Violence and State Repression [WSS], 2015).

The year 2013 spawned new movements among the youth and especially among students. Examples include Hyderabad For Feminism, an online forum for combatting violence and harassment in the city (Joshua, Wahlang, & Madabhushi, 2015); the "Why Loiter" groups that demanded negotiating with public urban spaces and a redefinition of what counts as safety[6]; the 'Pinjra Tod' (break the cage) movement in Delhi's colleges and universities, calling for an end to discrimination in women's hostels (Raman, n.d.); and transgender groups in cities like Hyderabad, Bengaluru and Chennai that

raised the curtain on the extent of everyday sexual violence and humiliation they were subjected to by the police (Banerjie, 2016). Needless to add, this is only an incomplete illustrative list.

So there can be little doubt that this was clearly a moment of creative upsurge, public outcry and accountability, and of long awaited legal reform.[7] Despite this, I developed a sense of disquiet. As I will explain below this is because the strong responses to harassment and violence engendered by this moment also appeared, at the same time, to have the disabling effect of obscuring the contexts that shaped and constrained young people's and especially young women's destinies. Our initial response as feminists had been to deny the exceptional status accorded to sexual violence in India by a sensation-seeking media both local and global. However, I also believed that India was indeed exceptional, though for reasons that were deeper and stranger.

While it is yet to be elaborated and justified, my basic argument is that what makes India exceptional is the paradoxical juxtaposition of near gender parity in access to higher education and the very low proportion of women in gainful employment. And yet, this unique predicament has somehow failed to attract public attention. Indeed, even the women's movement (especially its autonomous face) has not cared enough to make this a political issue. Where is the ire if not rage over the very contexts within which violence is endemic?

Sexual harassment in higher education

Let me lay out my misgivings in relation to higher education, where—or so I thought till #MeToo came to India in 2017—issues of sexual harassment had been sufficiently scrutinized and politicized. I was brought into a direct relationship with this situation when the University Grants Commission (UGC) set up a Task Force in January 2013 (as an immediate response to the Delhi gang rape) "to review the existing arrangements that have been put in place on the campuses … to ensure the freedom, safety and security of girls and women in particular and of the entire youth population in general" (UGC, 2013, p. 95). The Task Force (of which I was a member) was given the opportunity to investigate how universities were tackling sexual harassment and providing gender sensitization and its results came out in the form of a UGC Report (*Saksham*). Open Forums were conducted in a number of universities and a broader glimpse of the state of affairs in many more institutions was obtained by sending out questionnaires to all the constituent colleges and universities under the UGC's jurisdiction. To those of a generation who recalled the campaigns against "eve-teasing" of the 1970s and 1980s these testimonies came as a major surprise; we had assumed that much would have improved in the interim (see John, 2015–16).

If one had to sum up the findings as briefly as possible they would be thus: the subject of sexual harassment was at best a matter of considerable confusion and more frequently one of outright denial, especially among administrators and teachers, while one of the weakest aspect of India's institutions of higher education turned out to be their lack of gender sensitivity. The Task Force heard over and over again about the pervasive vulnerability to forms of sexual harassment that constituted the everyday lives of women students on campuses. This was exacerbated by the lack of basic facilities—public transport, lighting, hostel accommodation, health care and counseling, on the one hand, and compounded when gender was reinforced by other structures of discrimination and disadvantage—by rural location, caste, class, minority status, disability and sexuality, on the other.

In peri-urban and rural areas, students testified that they could only get to college by tractor; but even in the heart of India's metros, the lack of public transport in a sprawling campus made many women dependent on male students with motorbikes for their "little daily needs," who then expected "favours" in return, in a classic quid pro quo mode. Women students wearing hijabs received frequent comments and taunts, while those from the states of the North-East were subjected to propositioning should they venture out for a walk in the evenings.

Very few members of higher educational institutions took the need for gender sensitization seriously, in spite of how critical it was for creating a conducive atmosphere on campus in relation to gender equality and freedom from harassment. Moreover, given the heterogeneous nature of student populations, who not only studied but often lived together for many years, it was not just experiences of discrimination but different ideas about "appropriate" behavior that created confusion and alienation among students.

The university or college—precisely because their purpose is education—should have been places especially well placed to think further about equality, to enable students to take risks and experiment, to learn how to not just tolerate but live well with others who were different (socially, economically, in terms of religion, caste, gender, sexuality, or ability). The UGC Report attempted to capture the views of students who strongly and repeatedly articulated that a university should help a woman "transition from the protected atmosphere of the home into a real life situation where she had to be independent" (UGC, 2013, p. 37).

The greatest obstacle to gender sensitization was the typical approach evinced by university and college administrations for dealing with the presence of significant numbers of women students, namely protectionism and policing. In the wake of the Delhi gang rape, while students took out marches and held vigils for greater freedom and justice, authorities in many parts of the country responded by making their rules for women students even more stringent than they were before the incident. Hostel timings

were curtailed and "night outs" canceled. Most troubling of all was the exposure of the most effective method for silencing students: especially in undergraduate colleges and privately managed institutions there appeared to be a kind of unspoken pact between the administration and parents, whereby discriminatory rules had to be tolerated if not respected, even though they were oriented towards blaming the victim. If students spoke up or acted against such rules, the result could well be one of being asked to leave. Here again, it was only too obvious as to which students would be most vulnerable to this kind of threat: those already battling "convention" bound family backgrounds, with limited economic resources, coming from marginal communities and locations. In such a situation, several students said that it would be better to quietly endure the daily humiliations and constraints, than to risk giving up these precious few years.

The UGC Report was produced a year after the Delhi gang rape and then accepted as guidelines by the UGC. It had been hoped that these would therefore be the basis for a new set of regulations to deal with sexual harassment on campuses. Regulations were indeed created in 2016 by a new team and with the involvement of several government ministries, but unfortunately their narrow focus on Internal Complaints Committees (ICCs) did not appear to carry enough of the spirit of the UGC Report forward.

Such disappointment apart, my concern in those years was to draw attention to what I perceived to be as critical for students and their futures. In all the turmoil, one of the most remarkable facets of higher education was either being taken for granted or bypassed altogether; namely the extraordinary entry and visibility of women students at a time of unprecedented expansion and privatization.

Gender parity in higher education

To put this unique moment in the history of higher education in some perspective: Right after Independence (in 1950), there were approximately a hundred thousand students enrolled in the nation's colleges and universities, at a time when all Indian universities were state-run and charged practically no fees. According to the All India Survey of Higher Education (AISHE) Report (Department of Higher Education, 2018), this number stood at a staggering 36.6 million in 2017–18, with over one hundred thousand enrolled at the PhD level alone. With over 900 universities, 40,000 colleges and 10,000 standalone institutions, India has the largest system of higher education in the world, and the second largest (after China) in terms of the sheer number of students enrolled. Much of this growth has been very recent, with enrollment rates doubling in the last decade to reach 25% in the age group 18–23 years.

But hear this: just 10% of students at the time of Independence were women. Yet, by the year 2000 this figure had jumped to 40%, and has been inching forward to reach 47.6% in 2017–18. Being an average number covering every kind of institution that offers a degree after class 12, this figure hides the unevenness of female enrollment, especially the continued male bias in institutions of national importance (which include the prestigious Indian Institutes of Technology and Indian Institutes of Management, BTech and Engineering courses, and state private universities.) But one would be quite wrong to think that young women are simply crowding into the countless but relatively small education colleges and other teacher training shops that have been mushrooming all across the country. There is no getting away from the overall fact that what a few decades ago was still an elite male bastion has decisively given way to a situation close to gender parity, when it came to student enrollments**.** In no other public institutional space (where gender inequalities are otherwise so rife) is there anything remotely like this.

The unprecedented entry of women into India's colleges and universities has been happening alongside democratization of access on other fronts as well. Thanks in large part to the implementation of caste based reservations (quotas), out of 100 students in 2017–18 (again these are all India averages), 14.4% were Scheduled Caste, 35% Other Backward Classes (OBC), and 5.2% Scheduled Tribes. There were also 5% Muslims, and 2.2% other minorities, which left about 38% Hindu upper castes (Department of Higher Education, 2018). So while upper castes (who constitute an estimated 15% to 20% of the population) are still quite over represented, and Muslims and Persons with Disability in particular are severely underrepresented, the student body has become much more heterogeneous than before and the situation has been broadly improving over the years.

Of course, much more needs to be said about what kind of space this is, as the movement to fight the institutional suicide of the Ph.D. student Rohith Vemula (at the University of Hyderabad in January 2016), among many such struggles, was forcing people to ask (Shantha, 2018). Scheduled Tribes have been only increasing marginally, while Muslims seemed to be losing the small foothold they had a decade ago. On the other hand, even those who do not show up in government statistics—like sexual minorities—have a more visible presence on our campuses.

Cutting through all these developments has been the growing presence of women across every group. Even among the most under represented, such as Muslims, close to half are women. Therefore, there is now a very significant heterogeneity among women too, as more women from hitherto excluded social and economic locations were gaining entry. This kind of democratization is hugely important. How should we view this? Was this simply a "normal" process, as families aspired for upward mobility for daughters as well as sons? Or could there be something more potentially "revolutionary"

in the making? These were the kinds of questions that I felt needed to be posed alongside the high visibility being accorded to the pervasiveness of sexual harassment on campuses. Such was the potency of sexual harassment as a touchstone that it provided both the language and frame for students and even the UGC to stake out a hope for making young women's lives a more genuinely fulfilling and less humiliating experience. Women were claiming the space of higher education where they wished to transit from the protected sphere of the home to that of greater independence. But was this in fact the case? What happened afterwards?

The crisis in employment

This brings me to the other part of my narrative. While many administrators think of it as a sort of creche for young adults, and some despairing students refer to their years in it as "timepass,"[8] Indian higher education has nevertheless managed to become an exceptional bubble of relative gender parity. But India's work places present a starkly different picture. Since the 1970s, the burden of many scholars and activists in India had been to show that our data sets on women's work are fundamentally misleading: women are engaged in productive economic work of all kinds, but our national accounting systems are unable to capture and measure this. With a strong focus on rural India, where the majority of the population still resides, decades of analysis, especially among development economists, had gone to show how much work, including productive labor beyond conventional notions of housework, is being undertaken by women, but without acknowledgement (Banerjee & Jain, 1985; Hirway, 2005; Jhabvala & Subramanya, 2000). Already by the early 1990s, major international bodies, such as the World Bank, were revising their pictures, with announcements to the effect that if all the labor were counted, women worked longer and harder than men, but with fewer returns (Bennett, 1991). This is a very real contradiction—on the one hand, the Indian economy, with an increasingly neo-liberal face, is being effectively subsidized by the huge proportion of women's unpaid labor necessary for the reproduction of society, and in fact would collapse if it were adequately remunerated by employers or the state. On the other hand, and precisely because such labor is without acknowledgement, there continues to be a widespread devaluation of women in societies such as ours.

At the same time, some scholars and feminists were arguing that this did not resolve the huge gap that is recorded between men and women in India's overall paid work force, especially in urban areas. After all is said and done, not to put too fine a point on it, India has one of the lowest female work participation rates in the world (the only countries worse than India are in West Asia!), and this fact is only now gaining a little traction. Drawing from national data from the 1980s to 2011–12, some have spoken of an

overall decline in women's work, others notice levels of volatility, oscillating nonetheless around a very low average, especially in the realm of paid work, where National Sample Survey Office (NSSO) figures for 2011–12 are 15% (Neetha, 2014; see also Ghosh, 2009; Mazumdar & Neetha, 2011).

These low rates coincided with a period (from the 1990s till 2015 or so) when India was witnessing the highest growth rates in its economy, and where a certain common sense would have one believe that India was therefore enjoying unprecedented job opportunities. But what the data in fact was saying is that the economic regime was one where the vast majority of all women, however long and hard many of them may have been working—at home, on family farms, in various artisanal or other productive contexts—were effectively living in relations of dependency, fundamentally attached to households, since they were engaging in some form or other of unpaid family labor. These relations of dependency, while initially those of a daughter, are subsequently invariably structured by marriage. And from what we know about the lack of any effective implementation of property rights for those with land, assets or other forms of capital, this means registering the enormity of such dependency and its wider ramifications for any discussion of women's chances for autonomy in India, including, most definitely, freedom from sexual harassment and violence.

Furthermore, there has also been a distinct, persistent class, caste and community dimension to women's paid and unpaid work, which is playing a significant role in structuring India's labor markets. While a proper account would not be possible here, a few issues do stand out, all of them disturbing. Once the differences between men and women's labor situations are further disaggregated, Neetha (2014) has demonstrated that there has been an overall intensification of inequalities between women, one that aligns with their Scheduled Tribe, Scheduled Caste, Other Backward Classes, Muslim and upper-caste statuses. Thus, for instance, the last major round of NSSO data for 2011–12 reveals that in a situation of overall decline in female employment, Scheduled Tribes, Scheduled Castes and OBCs (in that order) have lost out the most job-wise, and that too, in a context where they are already marginalized and confined to the most onerous sectors of work (Neetha, 2014). A small proportion of upper-caste women, especially in urban India, have, on the other hand, found a few enclaves, such that their relative privilege in social and educational terms translates into cornering not just the more traditional fields of education, but the hyper-visible ones relating to finance, real estate and the media. This means that labor markets that are supposedly neutral are actually places where both stigma and discrimination are rife.

In 2019, another round of national data on employment called the Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS) that came out from the National Sample Survey Organisation, provided information for the year 2017–18, but was sought to be suppressed by the Indian government. This was because its numbers

actually showed an unprecedented absolute decline in the total number of workers from 2011–12 to 2017–18, with very high rates of people dropping out of the work force or reporting themselves as unemployed. This data is currently the source of much debate, and so I will not dwell on it unduly here. It suggests that the worst declines have been among women who are less educated and in rural areas, with small gains for women with educational levels beyond high school, especially among upper caste groups. But even here these gains are taking place in a variety of low level urban service sector jobs earlier open to those with less education, but where computerization and technological changes could now be favoring those who have gone beyond high school (Chandhrasekher & Ghosh, 2020; Kannan & Raveendran, 2019).

This does not change the fact that barely 15% of women have any kind of paid work, nor that this figure was declining during the 1990s and 2000s which were the very years when Indian growth rates were the highest. Nor can it be denied that in our cities and towns, primary school teaching and paid domestic work still represent the largest concentrations of urban female workers. This means that while more and more women have indeed gained entry into higher education as never before, and from increasingly diverse social and economic backgrounds, only small proportions of them will find employment once they leave, however accomplished and well educated they might be, and however much they may have invested in their education. Moreover, even the present government cannot suppress the fact that India has entered a severe economic slowdown, at least since 2018 if not earlier, whose consequences have yet to be grasped. One can wonder whether such a situation might even go on to reverse the kinds of gains that have been seen in terms of educational attainments.

This then is the drift of my arguments so far. In the midst of all the clamor for freedom from violence that characterized the years following the Delhi gang rape, I had hoped for an equal focus on the context constraining young people's futures, and especially those of women who were accessing higher education. On several occasions I even urged that violence had been discussed adequately, although informal conversations with students and in women's groups claimed otherwise. They said that too much was still being left unsaid and turned out to be right.

The lens of #MeToo in India

Then came the #MeToo movement of 2017, which took everyone by surprise. Unlike the shocked international finger pointing of December 2012, in 2017 India was not quarantined in a state of exception. The voices of the #MeToo survivors bore testimony to the ubiquity of sexual harassment and violence in a country like the USA. What became suddenly available was

not just a common language for "breaking the silence" and gaining global credibility, but also ways of telling. Varied forms of bearing witness—from personal testimonies to anonymous lists of male harassers—cascaded from Hollywood, the American media, and to a lesser degree, US academia in an escalating, expanding spiral that "went viral" across the globe. If the language of silence seemed to hark back to the feminism of the 1970s, this was no simple return to old vocabularies. A new kind of media-based activism seemed to animate it, led by a new generation (Bennett, 2018; Thomson, 2018).

India too has been in the midst of acknowledging its #MeToo movement. In October 2017 Raya Sarkar, a law student studying in the US, brought out a crowd sourced list of Indian men in academia anonymously accused of sexual harassment on Facebook. Less than a year later, voices emerged from the film industry, journalism, the field of comedy, the art world, and the NGO sector, among others. Their accounts of experiences of sexual harassment (sometimes recalled many years after the event) garnered much greater publicity through the medium of Twitter. Painful and traumatic sexual and intimate relations became subjects that could be shared on social media platforms. In all of these situations men were called to account in unprecedented ways. I believe that these events have introduced us to new registers and dimensions for the problems that had otherwise become so familiar in the wake of the Delhi gang rape. I cannot hope to do justice to much of what is still in the process of unfolding, including the constitutive role being played by the new social media (which was no doubt already quite central after December 2012, but not in the way it is now).

Since it is formed through such direct global influence, the #MeToo moment might seem to be a suspect way in which one has to think afresh about the transformative potential of movements against sexual harassment in India. Certainly, this was not how I had anticipated that women's embattled presence in higher education and in employment would ultimately gain some public traction. The unexpected lesson here is not only that questions surrounding sexual harassment and violence have not been exhausted, but that they may also further our understanding about what makes the situation of women in our context so difficult to address today. In other words, thinking with (not against) the touchstone of violence might actually serve us better. Let me try and explain.

The first set of issues is that of a different voice since the onset of #MeToo, from within a critically active new generation. Ritty Lukose has suggested in the US context that it is the changing sexual politics of the times that has made the younger feminists leading #MeToo—who have grown up in a sexually permissive if not sex-saturated world—draw on notions of exploitation and victimhood that an older generation had become quite wary of (Lukose, 2018). I do not wish to suggest that this is true of our world too,

but there are significant connections all the same. We lack a good description of how much things have changed since the 1990s when sexuality entered public life and movement politics in India. Many millennials are raising doubts of their own about how the desire for greater sexual freedom in repressive contexts like ours has had the effect of making sex-positivism into an imperative but with less than liberatory outcomes. In particular, what was claimed to be a progressive attitude from men, especially in heterosexual relations, has all too often turned into an experience of violation that is very hard to acknowledge, let alone name, and so much more so for anyone whose vulnerability is compounded along other axes of discrimination. For many from my generation that allied with sexuality movements, sex positivity appeared as an advance or even as a counter to violence. Desire and consent have been the watchwords. This way of thinking stands challenged now, and the challenge has come from those who have voiced their experiences of sexual harassment, not from an established feminist leadership representing their cause.

Another set of questions has been forced on us in the context of the university. The list LoSHA "naming and shaming" academics (many of whom were renowned and admired for their progressive scholarship) has been among the more controversial aspects of #MeToo politics in India.[9] In my view its misleading polarization in opposition to due process became an obstacle to recognizing what was so disturbing about it and was not just a matter of dismay. It gestured towards a problem regarding universities that needed to be grasped prior to and alongside mechanisms of redressal. Looking back at the UGC Report (*Saksham*) of 2013 with the benefit of hindsight, I would say that in its aim to push for the gender sensitization of a heterogeneous student body within a broadly liberal culture, it underestimated how university structures and faculty networks were shaping students' worlds and their futures. What kind of workplace is the university and how should one characterize the relationship between faculty and students, who are not to each other as employer is to employee? While everyone may acknowledge the power differential between teacher and student, there is much more at stake. By virtue of being a relationship of learning and influence, sometimes profoundly so, the pedagogic dimensions of the relationship extend further. This can make the institutional culture of universities quite different from that of modern workplaces. Paradoxically, in an effort to capture the ties that bind students to their teachers, commentators have described universities across the world as more feudal than capitalist, and I believe this would be even truer in India. In such situations, the sexual politics of teacher student relations become all the more difficult to address, especially when hierarchies are masked by liberal claims. The near parity in gendered terms among the student population that I referred to earlier contrasts sharply with the social composition of faculty who are overwhelmingly

male and upper caste. An anonymous list is an ambivalent phenomenon: On the one hand, there was no knowing what the accusations were, how they fit within existing definitions of sexual harassment, perhaps indicative of other experiences of discrimination and violation. On the other hand, the characteristic of a list is to go beyond individuals to gesture towards a larger problem, in this case an academic culture of widespread immunity, in which a potential complainant might well be worse off by coming forward with her complaint rather than obtaining relief. One can better discern the specific vulnerabilities of students in the #MeToo era in India. In spite of universities having been the sites of so much mobilizing against sexual harassment and for so long, it has been that much harder to call out harassers among faculty than in other workplaces, where some very famous men have been brought low.[10]

This brings me to yet another set of questions—the very new visibility of some workplaces as sites of sexual harassment. Interestingly, these have not been the more familiar "traditional" ones, but those such as the media and entertainment industries, where a small but critical mass of women is barely a generation old.[11] We already have accounts from, and lively debates among, journalists of different generations that attest to this new situation. What has made it possible for this generation of women holding jobs in male dominated work cultures to speak up as some of them have? Proliferating discussions have been offline as much as online. Questions have been raised about the relative privilege of these #MeToo voices in terms of caste and class. Doubtless there are those whose testimonies have shown that they are unable or unwilling to acknowledge the extent to which this privilege has worked in their favor. Still others have evinced a remarkable capacity for reflexivity, acknowledging, for example, how class advantage or familial support were critical for enduring the mental anguish they were subjected to when they spoke out. But one should be careful not to generalize. In the case of the Telugu film industry it was women and trans people at the bottom of the pyramid who raised their voices, combining economic exploitation and sexual harassment with discrimination based on caste and skin color.[12] Moreover, high profile support in some quarters has gone hand in hand with backlash, denial, and forced retractions. This is the paradox thrown up by #MeToo in contemporary India: the very time when the vast majority of women have been condemned to relations of financial and economic dependency on men, has also become the time when sexual violation is being named in unprecedented ways and men are being called to account.

In her recent book *Fortunes of Feminism: From State Managed Capitalism to Neoliberal Crisis,* Nancy Fraser (2012) has raised some provocative questions about the "coincidence" of the prospering of second-wave feminism in the era of neo-liberalism in western societies. "Was there some perverse, subterranean, elective affinity between them" she asks? (Fraser, 2012, p. 218). Rather than her worry about the heightened emphasis on identity politics

at the cost of critiques of capitalism, I am more concerned about the considerable focus on sexual violence and harassment that has been unfolding. Curiously, this appears to be a genuinely global moment, one that is bringing together countries as far apart as India and the USA. Neo-liberalism in India had taken the road of "jobless growth" and if the latest data is to be believed is now shifting to "job loss growth" (Kannan & Raveendran, 2019) and a new experience of economic slowdown in a context of very low if not declining decent work opportunities for women, along with hitherto rising rates of access to higher education. As we have seen, successive waves of politicizing the spaces of higher education have sought to name the vulnerability of the woman student through the language of sexual harassment. In a situation where future prospects are ringed with so much uncertainty, wherein the chances and costs of lodging formal complaints have every probability of backfiring, what else needs to be done by way of supporting students in this critical phase of their lives? Late in the day, new workplaces have become sites where sexual violations have been called to account. These voices are as yet few and far between, occupying as they do hugely divergent but relatively small enclaves of employment. Nor are there signs yet of how these voices connect to other platforms of women workers; consider the lakhs of garment workers in Bengaluru. Their testimonies have borne witness to the ubiquity of harassment, wage theft and harsh levels of exploitation and in 2016 they successfully struck work in order to be able to access their provident fund (Johnson, 2016) (see also the introduction and essays in John and Gopal (in press)).

We know far too little about how women are negotiating, entering, or leaving employment, and we have not cared enough that the majority are simply excluded from it and have to depend entirely on men to bring their earnings home. It is even more troubling that this applies with greater force to a younger generation investing more years and money into their education than ever before. I am *not* suggesting that we take the route of simply rejecting the relative ease with which liberal notions of perpetrators of harassment and violence can now be called out while a language to fight economic and financial structures of exclusion is proving so elusive. It is certainly not my argument that any opposition to sexual violence is deficient on account of its individualism. The force of the #MeToo moment across the globe has in fact used the politics of lists and collective testimonies to reveal deep structures of power and immunity.

It does, however, call for special vigilance and understanding about the kinds of resources available to combat experiences of injustice. This brings to mind the concept of "hermeneutic injustice" coined by Miranda Fricker (2006). In her telling, "hermeneutic injustice" occurs when members of a disadvantaged group are unable to make proper sense of their experiences and a "whole engine of collective social meaning [is] effectively geared to keeping

these obscured experiences out of sight" (Fricker, 2006, p. 99). Being disabled as knowers thus constitutes an injustice. It is quite remarkable that Fricker's key example of such injustice is an American woman whose experience of sexual harassment in her job in the early days of second wave feminism was one for which she had no name, let alone any recourse, and with profoundly negative consequences. Should we then say that a different kind of hermeneutic injustice may be emerging at a time when the languages of sexual harassment have offered repeated political and interpretive resources for the powerless but at the cost of relative inattention to the unjust contexts that are fully at work?

At the same time, new dangers are now looming. Since November 2019 India has been witness to the extraordinary and ongoing efforts by women and students who have been peacefully protesting the current state's actions to amend our citizenship laws, actions on the part of the state that are not just unconstitutional but threaten to turn unknown numbers of our people into non-citizens. At the very least, we therefore need to care more by responding to the modes in which protests are being articulated and rearticulated, in order to make other futures possible.

Acknowledgements

This article has been in the making over several years and began in a very truncated form in the months following the 16 December 2012 gang rape. The ideas structuring this essay have been presented on many occasions in different places and I wish to place on record how important the responses and feedback have been in giving it its present shape. I owe a unique debt to the students of the Women and Gender Studies Programme (Ambedkar University Delhi and Centre for Women's Development Studies, New Delhi) and to the numerous discussions and interventions by members of the women's organization Women against Sexual Violence and State Repression. An earlier version of this essay appeared in the online magazine *The India Forum*, in March 2019. I thank the Asian Association of Women's Studies (AAWS) for inviting me to present a version in the form of a keynote address at their Fifth Congress held at Ewha Womans University in Seoul, Korea in December 2019. I am grateful to the two anonymous reviewers for their valuable inputs and questions (which could not always be adequately answered), and particularly to the editors of this journal for the care they have taken in the publication of this article. With so many accumulated debts, nonetheless the usual disclaimers remain.

Notes

1. The literature on violence and the women's movement is large and growing, especially when it comes to campaigns and legal reforms. For a concise overview, see Kannabiran and Menon (2007), one that demonstrates the special feminist focus on state agents in the perpetration of violence. The Open letter by Upendra Baxi, Vasudha Dhagamvar, Raghunath Kelkar and Lotika Sarkar that sparked off the campaign against rape in 1978 can be accessed in Baxi,

Dhagamwar, Kelkar, & Sarkar (2008). For a critique of the legal frameworks relating to violence, see Nivedita Menon (2004).

2. For some examples of the media coverage of the Delhi attack, see Banerji's (2012) "Public fury over New Delhi gang-rape" and "2012 Delhi gangrape case: A timeline of events" (2017) published by *Live Mint*.
3. For a letter written by a group of feminists in India in response to the announcement of the Gender Task Force at Harvard see Menon, N. (2013). For an example of the strong reaction to Leslee Udwin's film see Hazra (2015).
4. The Home Ministry of the Government of India brings out national data on crimes on an annual basis (see various years of NCRB). The 98% figure corresponds to rape data for the year 2011–12, which emerged in public discussions that followed the Delhi gang rape. The equivalent figure is 95% for the most recent year 2017–18 for which data is available.
5. The study was conducted by the Maharashtra Department of Women and Child Development with Majlis Legal Centre, based on 644 FIRs lodged by the Mumbai police between August 2008 and July 2015. During this period, 9% were cases of stranger rape and 7.2% were ones of incest by fathers (Rahat, 2015).
6. The "Why Loiter" groups took inspiration from a book by that title that had come out a year before the gang rape, but these groups became active in the wake of the protests (see Phadke, Khan, & Ranade, 2011).
7. One should not of course overstate the progressive consequences of all these protests and discussions. Certainly no claims can be made about the deterrent effects on acts of violence since 2012. Neither data on reported crimes nor the incidence of acts of sexual violence, including by men in positions of great influence have abated. Nor can it be said that feminist arguments against the death penalty have made sufficient headway so far. In a particularly horrific instance that took place near Hyderabad in November 2019, the police killed four suspects they had taken into custody whom they claimed had raped and murdered a young woman veterinarian. Equally disturbing as the unfolding events was the media coverage reporting public celebration of these extra-judicial killings (Daga & Francis, 2019).
8. This is the title of a book on university students in the north Indian town of Meerut by Craig Jeffrey (2010).
9. For a sense of the kind of controversy that followed the publishing of LoSHA (an acronym for List of Sexual Harassers in Academia), see Online Desk (New Indian Express, 2017a, 2017b), Menon (2017), Pal (2017), WSS (2017), Ghosh (2017). A particularly strong reaction followed the "directive" from the 'kafila' statement (Menon, 2017) to take down the list and follow due process. Away from the glare of Facebook, smaller groups were able to find a more dialogical space for engaging with the meanings of the list and its politics, such as on the e-group feministsindia. Raya Sarkar has maintained that the purpose of the list was not punitive but cautionary.
10. Given that the social media has been such a powerful, if not over-determining, presence and constitutive force, it is vital to acknowledge the critical place that "offline" meetings and panel discussions occupied in the wake of catalytic events such as LOSHA within university contexts. The student Feminist Collective in Jawaharlal Nehru University in Delhi organized a night discussion "Breaking the Silence: Sexual Harassment in Academia" on 14 November 2017 in a university that had become particularly polarized over questions of "due process" and accusations that anyone who was supportive of the Facebook

list was guilty of vigilante justice. Students of Ambedkar University Delhi held their own events the following year, including a discussion "Questioning the Silence: A Panel Discussion on Cultures of Sexual Harassment in Academia" on 4th April 2018. To get a sense of the kinds of questions they were raising, here is a quote from the concept note they had prepared for invited speakers: "This discussion seeks to engage with deeper structural problems with the institutional cultures of universities that appear to facilitate and produce the conditions for sexual harassment of a variety that cannot always be named as such. Certain practices in the classroom, in the name of being liberal and sex-positive, present the exchange of erotic ideas and sexual relations between students and teachers as being outside the power hierarchy that inadvertently structures them. A significant strand of discussion is focused on how these accusations of sexual harassment are merely "consensual relationships gone wrong." Questions need to be asked about "consent" and "agency"—when the sexual relations are in a situation of unequal power, how do we understand consent? Can consent truly exist in these situations? What does "yes" mean and what are the conditions of producing this "yes"? Thirdly, if women students are "exercising agency" by entering such relationships, questions need to be asked about whether agency is independent of structural imbalances within which it is exercised. How do these experiences of sexual harassment of students vary across their intersecting identities?"

11. Here are a few of the more well known cases from this #MeToo moment: the accusation against the comedian Utsav Chakraborty of the group All India Bakchod by another comedian (Hindustan Times, 2018); the journalist Sandhya Menon's testimony against the senior journalist M K Akbar (Goel, Venkataraman, & Schultz, 2018), which in turn evoked more discussion and debate from other newspaper journalists (Singh, 2018; Philipose, 2019); the many protests and testimonies from the film industry—in Kerala accusations against a major actor Dilip led to the formation of the Women in Cinema Collective; Tanushree Dutta accused fellow Hindi film actor Nana Patekar, recalling his harassment of her in 2008, setting off further anonymous testimonies such as one against well-known film director Rajkumar Hirani (Mitra, 2019), among others. These testimonies openly used the hashtag #MeToo and in turn snowballed into more revelations, online sharing and discussions, thus creating a larger climate of reckoning. Just prior to this #MeToo phenomenon India witnessed very significant cases such as those against the Tehelka magazine chief Tarun Tejpal (Shukla, 2017), the artist Mohammad Farooqui (Aiyar, 2018) and the head of TERI (The Energy Research Institute), R K Pachauri (Sharma, 2018). However—and not only because these were fought in courts of law—public discussions around them did not trigger the collective testimonial climate so characteristic of #MeToo.
12. Women's groups in Telengana have been particularly active in providing support to the protests led by women and transpersons in the Telugu film industry (see Anveshi, 2019).

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